

APPENDIX III

METHODS OF BIBLE SHARING

1. The Seven-Step Method (Lumko Institute, South Africa)

FIRST STEP: We invite the Lord

Once the group settles down, the facilitator asks someone to volunteer "to invite the Lord." The belief in the living presence of the Risen Christ in our midst is the presupposition and basis of our meditation. We want to meet the Word who became flesh and dwells among us. We remember Jesus' promise: "Where two or three are gathered in my name, I shall be there with them." (Matt 18,20).

SECOND STEP: We read the text

The facilitator announces the chosen text (first the book, then the chapter). He/she waits until everyone has found the chapter and only then is the verse announced. When everyone has found the passage, the facilitator invites someone to volunteer to read the text. A moment of silence follows.

THIRD STEP: We dwell on the text

The facilitator continues: "We dwell on the text. Which words strike you in a special way?" In doing this, almost the entire text is listened to again. The participants spontaneously read aloud the word or words that have impressed them. Whole verses are not read, only short phrases or individual words. The participants are encouraged to repeat those words silently to themselves three or four times. It is extremely important that a moment of silence be kept after each person has spoken, allowing the message to "soak in." As a result of this step, "simple" words often take on new meaning.

FOURTH STEP: We are quiet

After spending time on the individual words, the entire passage is read again slowly. Then the facilitator announces a time of silence, giving the exact length of time, for example, three minutes. We advise the people to spend this time in silence before God. "We are open to God." "We allow ourselves to be loved by God." "We let God look at us." A helpful practice during this silence is to repeat a specific word. Meditation: Simply to be open to God, to wait for God, to be with God, "in fact he is not far from any of us" (Acts 17,27).

FIFTH STEP: We share what we have heard in our hearts

After the time of quiet, the facilitator announces the next step: "We share with each other what we have heard in our hearts." We do this to share with one another our faith experience and to help each other to grow in faith. The entire Sacred Scripture is nothing less than a God experience which the People of Israel and Jesus "share" with us. It is somewhat strange that we can talk to friends about almost every aspect of our life yet when it comes to sharing with others our experience with God, we become shy. In this Bible meditation method, however, anyone can learn "to risk" this sharing in a very natural and unpressured way.

SIXTH STEP: We search together

The facilitator announces: "We search together." Now the time has come for the participants to examine their lives in the light of the Gospel. At this stage, a basic community might discuss everyday problems as: Someone needs help in the neighborhood... Children need instruction in the faith... Who will lead the Service of the Word next Sunday, since the priest will not be there?... How can we settle a discord that has arisen?... What can we do about getting the street lamp repaired?... None of these problems needs to have a direct connection to the Bible passage which had been read and shared. However, they emerge and can be resolved because of the mutual confidence that now exists in an atmosphere of the presence of God. Things look different when God is allowed to be present.

SEVENTH STEP: We pray together

The facilitator now invites everyone to pray. The words of Scripture, the various experiences of God's Word, the daily problems - these all become fuel for prayer. Some find this form of sharing in prayer the easiest way to communicate with others. The participants are encouraged to incorporate in their personal prayer whatever has been of special importance to them during the meditation. Only at the end is a formal prayer known to everyone recited.

For more information on this method, contact the Lumko Institute at lumko@global.co.za

2. The Dzogbegan Ten-Step Method (Benedictine Monastery of Dzogbegan, Togo):

1. Sing a Psalm/Hymn – Biblical song (to create a prayerful atmosphere) “so that God and human beings may talk together” (*Dei Verbum* 25).
2. Prayer of invocation (it should be suitable and relevant).
3. Let us read the text aloud and then silently.
4. Now let us study the text:
 - a) examine the context - what comes before and after the passage;
 - b) structure: possible divisions, style, type of literature, etc.;
 - c) background: people, places, customs;
 - d) important, recurring and repeated words; important ideas and phrases;
 - e) inculturation: examine the biblical thought vis-à-vis African culture.

5. Let us look at the text comprehensively in the light of the entire Bible:

- a) the book in which the passage is found;
 - b) the group of books to which it belongs, e.g. the Gospels;
 - c) the New Testament;
 - d) the Old Testament.
 - e) What light does extra-biblical literature throw on the passage?
6. What is the church's understanding of the passage? Its doctrinal-traditional usage of the passage? Its liturgical usage of the passage?
7. Let us read the text again aloud and then summarise the message.
8. Sharing: Let us apply the text
- a) to our own personal life;
 - b) to our concrete situation;
 - c) to our society.
 - d) Let us find a possible Word of Life and memorise it.
 - e) What possible Action flows from the text (personal and communal)?

9. Concluding Prayer:

- psalm;
- prayer of intercession;
- prayer about the message.

10. Hymn based on the biblical message (as far as possible).

For more information about this method contact the generalate biblical coordinator's office at svd.bible@verbodivino.it

3. The Vigan Method (John Paul I Biblical Center, Vigan, Philippines):

Opening Prayer or Song

The participants are encouraged to become aware of God's presence. Jesus said, "Where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the midst of them" (Matt 18,20). A prayer of petition would also be appropriate, such as the words in Scripture: "Speak Lord, for your servant is listening" (1 Sam 3,10) or "You have the words of eternal life" (John 6,68). There can be a petition to the Holy Spirit, who can open our ears and free us from everything that would hinder us from hearing God's Word, or a hymn to the Holy Spirit - such as "Come, Holy Spirit."

First Step

First contact with the TEXT, with the "dead letter."

- *Reading the text:* One member of the group reads it aloud, the others participate by listening and/or reading it silently.

- *Silence:* After the reading, all observe silence for about three minutes, during which time they may go over the text once more in their minds. Each chooses a word (or words), a phrase (or phrases), a verse (or verses) which strikes them.

- *Sharing:* After about three minutes, the facilitator invites the group members to share the word, phrase or verse which struck them. They are not to give any explanation, only the word, phrase or verse with the corresponding verse number, e.g. "I was struck by the word 'light' in verse 5" (in 1 John 1). No explanation is given, nor any reason why this particular word, phrase or verse was found striking for the respective individual.

Second Step

The "dead letter" of Scripture becomes the "LIVING WORD" for each individual (and perhaps, through the individual, for others as well).

- *Reading the same text again:* After all have shared, upon the invitation of the facilitator another member reads the same text aloud. The others again participate silently.

- *Silence:* After the reading all observe deep silence for about five minutes, during which time each member listens intently to God's personal message to him/her. Prompted by the text and/or the sharing of the other group members, something will emerge as most meaningful to each group member, something true to their own experience or applicable to their own lives. While listening, the participants ask themselves, "What do you, God, want to tell me personally for my own life?"

- *Sharing of the Word for me with the others:* After about five minutes the facilitator invites the group members to share what they have heard in the depths of their hearts. In order to keep the sharing on a personal level and to refrain from moralizing, they will try to use only the first person singular (I, me, my, mine). It is a matter of simple sharing, not of discussion or of preaching in the sense of moralizing. The words of Pope Paul VI may be recorded here: "Is there any other way of handing on the gospel, than by transmitting to another person one's personal experience of faith?" (*Evangelii Nuntiandi*).

Third Step

The WORD demands a RESPONSE.

- *Reading the same text again:* After all have shared, another member of the group reads the text aloud for a third time, while the others listen and/or read silently.

- *Silence and personal answer to the WORD:* After the reading the group observes deep silence once again, during which time each individual tries to find an answer to what has been perceived as the personal Word of God. There ought to be a real correspondence between the Word and the answer, for instance, expressing one's trust if the Word was a promise or one's obedience if it was a command. The prayer

could also be praise and thanks, repentance, petition, or intercession (depending on the message received).

- *Sharing of the personal prayer response:* Each person expresses aloud the personal answer of his/her heart to the Word received, so that it may be confirmed through the "Amen" (expressed aloud or in silence) of the other participants.

Concluding Prayer or Song

A prayer of praise or thanks, a song, or the Lord's Prayer recited in common by the group, is a very fitting conclusion to this Bible Sharing

A detailed explanation of this method, plus the Action Response Model, can be found at www.c-b-f.org under biblical-pastoral ministry, methods and approaches (in English, French, German and Spanish).

4. The Korean Method of *Lectio Divina* (Catholic Bible Life Movement, Seoul, Korea):

As the group gathers, they calm down, observing silence.

IN THE TOTAL GROUP:

Greetings and Opening Prayer

1. Mutual greetings:

Leader: "By the light of the Word";

All respond: "And the Spirit of grace" (or other).

2. Opening Prayer: Sign of the Cross and spontaneous prayer by the leader.

3. Reading the text:

Aloud; each one taking one verse; each one lending his/her unique voice to the written text to become a living word.

The leader disperses the group into twos (dyads) as dialogue companions. He/she indicates the time when they will gather again.

IN SMALL UNITS OF TWO:

1. Mutual greetings:

One partner: "By the light of the Word"; the other: "And the Spirit of grace" (or other).

2. Paying attention to the breath and the text, the Spirit and the Word:

- Breathe deeply, calmly, meditatively, attuning yourself to the "Spirit breathing in you."
- Read the text once again in silence.
- Let yourself be touched, penetrated by one word, symbol, concept; take it as the bread for this day (cf. Exod 16.14) that comes to you like the dew and the rain.

3. Listening to the Word - listening to your companion:

- Share your "bread for the day" with your companion.
- Taking turns, one shares, the other listens, not engaging in dialogue.
- Listen with an open heart, pass no judgement, respect how the word is touching the other in a unique way.

Gather again in the total group:

- either the leader, at the suggested time, calls the members to assemble in the total group;
- or, as all dialogue partners remain in silence after they finish their sharing, the group gathers again.

IN THE TOTAL GROUP

1. Greetings:

Leader: "By light of the Word"; all respond: "And the Spirit of grace" (or other).

2. Reading the text:

All read aloud - even if the translations or languages are different.

Before starting:

- breathe deeply three times
- think of a person for whom you would like this text to become good news or word of encouragement, etc.

3. Sharing your companion's word for the day:

Be careful not to share your own insights but those of your companion.

4. Closing prayer

- The members of the group in turn formulate a short prayer of thanks, petition, intercession, etc.
- Together pray the "Our Father."

More information on this method can be obtained from:
cbim@catholic.or.kr or svita@nahmail.net or srmauracho@hotmail.com

5. A LATIN AMERICAN METHOD (Carlos Mesters):

At the beginning of the meeting

1. Pray for the light of the Holy Spirit.
2. Check if everyone has completed their assignment from the last meeting.

I. Starting from today's reality

1. Verify that the chosen theme is really appropriate today.
2. Use specifically chosen questions to deepen the conversation.

II. Studying and meditating on the text

1. Read the text.
2. Study the text:
 - a. Do a close reading of the text (literary level).
 - b. Look at the situation of the text's community (historical level).
 - c. Look for the message of the text (theological level).

III. Celebrating the Word

1. Share in a spirit of thanksgiving the insights and energy gained.
2. Articulate the commitment discovered and made during the study.
3. Sing or pray an appropriate psalm - other prayers can be added.